

Emerging Respiratory Virus SPOK-24 (formerly Virus X) – Australia

Situation Report – 2, published 29 October 2024 (Week 43)

Highlights

- Total of 141 confirmed hospitalizations across multiple Australian cities for severe respiratory infections negative for common respiratory viruses.
- Twelve confirmed deaths, including pediatric fatalities, all testing positive for SPOK-24 Virus.
- Virus. Clear evidence of sustained human-to-human transmission with an increasing geographical spread.
- SPOK-24 virus genome available on GenBank; PCR primers developed and distributed to national laboratories.
- WHO is monitoring risk levels and preparing for potential global response escalation.

CURRENT EPIDEMIOLOGICAL SITUATION			
1. Total Confirmed Hospitalizations (Negative for Common Respiratory Panels, Under Investigation for SPOK-24 Virus) - Week 43			
Location	Total Hospitalizations (Cumulative)	New (Week 43)	Atypical Pneumonia (%)
Brisbane Metro, QLD	115	+40	~12%
Townsville, QLD	8	+7	~10%
Cairns, QLD	1	+1	~9%
Sydney, NSW	15	+7	~15%
Melbourne, VIC	1	+1	~8%
TOTAL	141	+56	
2. Confirmed Deaths (All SPOK-24 Virus Positive)			
Location	Total Deaths (Cumulative)	New Deaths (Week 43)	
Brisbane Metro, QLD	9	+3	
Townsville, QLD	2	+1	
Sunshine Coast, QLD	1	+1	

TOTAL	12	+5
3. Transmission Patterns		
- Evidence of sustained human-to-human transmission across multiple Australian cities. - Nosocomial (hospital-acquired) transmission confirmed in Brisbane and Townsville hospitals. - No confirmed international cases, but increased surveillance recommended.		

Public Health Actions Taken

- Testing & Diagnostics: All clinical samples from hospitalized respiratory patients negative for common viruses are being tested for SPOK-24 Virus at designated national labs.
- Case Identification & Contact Tracing: Expanded surveillance and contact tracing efforts are in place.
- Hospital Preparedness & Response: Infection control measures reinforced in healthcare settings.
- WHO Global Actions: WHO is assessing the risk of international spread and coordinating with Australian health authorities.

Risk Assessment

- Current Global Public Health Risk: HIGH (Based on increased transmission and hospitalizations).
- Likelihood of Global Spread: MODERATE-HIGH (Potential expansion beyond Australia).
- Risk of Severe Disease: Elevated in young children and elderly populations.

Recommendations For WHO Member States

- Enhanced Surveillance: Countries should increase screening for severe acute respiratory infections (SARI) and atypical pneumonia cases.
- Strengthened Laboratory Testing & Sequencing: National labs should use SPOK-24 Virus PCR primers and sequence positive cases where possible.
- Healthcare Preparedness: Hospitals should be on alert for unexplained severe respiratory cases.
- Public Health Communications: Governments should regularly update the public and healthcare workers on the evolving situation.

Next Steps & Global Response

- WHO Western Pacific Regional Office (WPRO) continues close collaboration with Australian health authorities.

- An Emergency Committee meeting is under consideration to assess whether this constitutes a Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC).
- WHO will issue an updated Situation Report in 7 days or as more information becomes available.
- For urgent inquiries and international reporting, contact the WHO IHR Emergency Team at [email contact].

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